here, for at all three places they considered horizontal faces best suited to their purpose. At Maski a more vertical face had been used, as also at Udegolam and Nittur. So, within each province the local officials seem to have had their own clear preferences when it came to deciding on an appropriate rock face to write on.

Coming back to Jatinga-Rameshwara: what makes it most dramatic is that the engravers, instead of using the base or an easily accessible part of the hill, carved his message on the summit. The hike to the hilltop, made relatively easy today by some 700 steps, must in Ashokan days have been steep and strenuous. The character of the landscape of this hilltop location in the third century BCE remains unknown from the range of religious associations presently visible there. The highest part of this spectacular rocky eminence, a little beyond the horizontal surface where the edicts were inscribed, we know to be a spot soaked in the mythology of the Ramayana story. It is known as ‘Jatayu sthana’ because it is here that the injured bird is believed by many to have fallen, even as Jatayu tried to rescue Sita. In the part of the rocky eminence that lies above and behind the edict-bearing rock lies a pond whose surrounding rock surface is marked by the impressions of human feet. Among these are a pair described as ‘Sita pada’ (the feet of Sita). There is nothing, though, that can help track such beliefs back to the time of the Mauryan emperor. The hilltop became famous over time as a pilgrimage spot called Balgoti Tirtha, a place of pilgrimage for devotees of the god Shiva under the name Rameshwara. Like Ashoka, many of the powerful royal patrons of this ‘tirtha’ inscribed their messages on rock surfaces and boulders. But that happened more than a millennium later.

In short, though we do not know what brought people to this hilltop in Mauryan times, the simple truth remains that no state functionaries would have taken the trouble to carve an important royal message at a place no one visited. My hunch is that the sheer physical grandeur of the Jatinga-Rameshwara hill, dominating everything in the landscape around it, was